own past against us. And how can we blame them, when such tactics succeeded as recently as 2007 when it came to the Quad? Strengthening a sense of independence or even autonomy does not necessarily mean staying at the centre or not making commitments. There is an inherent flexibility in that exercise, which somehow got lost when policy became dogmatic. Even today, tactical nimbleness and strategic creativity have a value that cannot be overstated.

At the end of the day, strategic clarity means both a sound understanding of the international environment as well a clear-eyed view of it from our national perspective. There have been shortcomings on both scores in our early periods after Independence and we paid a high price for it.

From the road taken, we must learn that national security can never take second place, least of all to the quest for prestige. In the final analysis, hard power will always score over soft power. Ideally, the two should be in lock-step, so that capabilities and influence grow side by side. But the desire for acceptance, particularly by competitors, should never become a significant driver of diplomacy. This realization from past experiences now drives India’s attitude towards world politics in general and our regional concerns in particular. As always, the wisdom and foresight of our tallest leaders serve as an inspiration for building Bharat.